



Clair Obscur: Expedition 33

Clair Obscur: Expedition 33^[a] is a 2025 role-playing video game developed by French studio Sandfall Interactive and published by Kepler Interactive. Taking place in a dark fantasy Belle Époque setting, the game follows the volunteers of Expedition 33 as they set out to destroy the Paintress, a being causing the yearly Gommage, which erases those at or above an ever-decreasing age. In the game, the player controls a party of characters from a third-person perspective, exploring areas and engaging in combat. Coupled with its turn-based mechanics are real-time aspects such as quick time events and timed actions in combat.

The game originated during the COVID-19 pandemic from ideas from Guillaume Broche, a Ubisoft employee; Broche would soon form Sandfall by reaching out to friends and contacts, establishing a 30-person core team whose project would come to be supported by various subcontractors. Inspired by Japanese RPGs that shaped their youth such as the *Final Fantasy* and *Persona* series, the developers at Sandfall sought to create a high-fidelity turn-based role-playing game, which they felt was neglected by AAA studios. Development began with Unreal Engine 4 and later switched to Unreal Engine 5, providing rendering improvements.

Clair Obscur: Expedition 33 was released for PlayStation 5, Windows, and Xbox Series X/S on 24 April 2025 to universal acclaim, selling over 3.3 million units within 33 days of release.^[3]

Gameplay

Clair Obscur: Expedition 33 is a third-person turn-based role-playing game with real-time elements. The player controls a party of Expeditioners exploring a fantasy world. On their turns, players select whether to use an item, perform a melee attack to gain Ability Points, or spend accumulated Ability Points to use

Clair Obscur: Expedition 33



Developer(s)	Sandfall Interactive
Publisher(s)	Kepler Interactive
Director(s)	Guillaume Broche
Producer(s)	François Meurisse
Designer(s)	Guillaume Broche Michel Nohra
Programmer(s)	Tom Guillermin
Artist(s)	Nicholas Maxson-Francombe
Writer(s)	Jennifer Svedberg-Yen Guillaume Broche Victor Deleard
Composer(s)	Lorien Testard Alice Duport-Percier (vocal) ^[1]
Engine	Unreal Engine 5
Platform(s)	PlayStation 5 Windows Xbox Series X/S
Release	24 April 2025



In this screenshot, Lune, Gustave, and Maelle are fighting against an enemy. On each turn, players can perform a basic melee attack, consume an item, use action points to shoot an enemy or use a skill.

ranged attacks or Skills.^[4]

Genre(s)

Role-playing

Mode(s)

Single-player

Ranged attacks are aimed freely, similar to a third-person shooter. When using a Skill, a quick time event can be completed for improved effects.^[5] During enemy turns, the player can dodge, parry, or jump over attacks in real time to avoid damage.^[6] Parrying requires more precise timing than dodging but provides Ability Points and the opportunity to counterattack.^[7] A stamina system allows players to "Break" enemies, temporarily stunning them.^[8] As players progress, the game introduces new attacks and parries, including Gradient Attacks, Gradient Counters, and Gradient Skills, all of which deal devastating damage. The use of gradient attacks

is monitored by a gauge shared by the party. It will slowly fill up when the party uses skills in combat.^[9] The Expeditioners and enemies can also apply various status effects on each other, boosting or impairing either side's combat efficiency. Some enemies have weak points that can be targeted, or may be vulnerable to certain elemental attacks.^[10] If the combat party is defeated, reserve characters may be called in to continue fighting. Combat ends when either side has no remaining combatants,^[7] or when the player decides to flee the battlefield when they are facing minor enemies.^[11]

The game features six playable characters, with each having unique skill trees, weapons and gameplay mechanics. The mage Lune's Skills generate elemental "Stains", which can be spent to enhance her Skills. The fencer Maelle switches between Stances which alter her Skills, damage and defense. The scythe-wielding warrior Sciel can use a set of magical cards to apply and stack "Foretell" to enemies, and then consume them to inflict maximum damage on enemies. Gustave and Verso deal more damage to enemies the more they attack them. Verso, in particular, gains "Perfection" ranks upon landing hits, and has increased damage output when he reaches a high Perfection rank. The Gestral Monoco can transform into enemies and use their abilities against them. Some of his abilities are further enhanced by his "Bestial Wheel", which spins whenever Monoco uses his abilities.^[12] When the party is not exploring or fighting enemies, they can rest at a camp. Assuming control of Verso, players can converse with other members of Expedition 33 and raise their relationship levels, unlocking new cinematics, skills and quests.^[13]

Combat encounters reward experience points, currency and upgrades. Each time a character levels up, they will gain three attribute points, which can be spent on increasing five core character stats: Vitality (maximum health), Might (attack power), Agility (frequency of attack), Defense (damage reduction), and Luck (critical rate).^[14] The abilities of the Expeditioners are further customized with equipable "Pictos" which add a variety of perks and further improve a character's stats. Each character can equip three Pictos at a time. Players can master the use of Pictos after using it in combat several times, unlocking its passive bonuses (known as Luminas) for other Expeditioners to use.^[15] Each character also has Lumina Points, which dictate how many Luminas they can equip at a time. As players level up, their maximum Lumina Points will increase, and players can also find additional Lumina Points as collectibles during exploration.^[16] As players explore, they will also collect "Chroma Catalysts", which can be used to upgrade weapons to higher levels at the camp.^[17] Higher-level weapons deal more base damage to enemies and offer additional gameplay perks.^[18]

While the game is set in linear levels, players can explore off the beaten path where they will find hidden resources, side quests, collectibles, character outfits, Gestral merchants, and optional bosses.^[19] Each level also has several Expedition Flags, where players heal their party, fast travel, restock items, and allocate attribute and skill points. Resting at an Expedition Flag respawns most enemies.^[15] Levels in the game are connected by an overworld map known as "The Continent".^[20] Eventually, the Expeditioners will meet Esquie, a mythical creature who helps the party to travel across the Continent. Esquie will acquire new transversal abilities as players progress, allowing it to swim, fly, and dive underwater.^[19] These new traversal abilities are essential for players to advance the story and access optional zones. The game has multiple difficulty options^[21] and a New Game Plus mode, allowing the player to replay the game with more difficult battles while retaining all character progression from their first playthrough.^[22]

Synopsis

Premise

Clair Obscur: Expedition 33 takes place in a dark fantasy Belle Époque setting. Every year for the past 67 years, the people of the isolated island of Lumière have suffered an event called the "Gommage"^[b], where an entity, known as "the Paintress" (Tracy Wiles), paints an ever-decreasing number on a rock formation known as the Monolith, and all humans with an age equal to or above that number disappear. Every year after the Gommage, Lumière sends an Expedition of volunteers to head to the mainland in an effort to slay the Paintress before she can paint a new number. Expedition 33 is the latest to set out.^{[24][25]}

Members of Expedition 33 include: Gustave (Charlie Cox), a resourceful engineer with a mechanical arm; Maelle (Jennifer English), the youngest member of the Expedition and Gustave's foster sister; Lune (Kirsty Rider), a brilliant scholar and mage; and Sciel (Shala Nyx), a calm and cheerful warrior. As the Expedition traverses the mainland, they encounter various individuals, including: Renoir (Andy Serkis), an old man driven by a ruthless determination; Verso (Ben Starr), a mysterious stranger who keeps watch of the Expedition; Monoco (Rich Keeble), one of the construct-like Gestrals who lives in the mainland and is associated with Verso; and Esquie (Maxence Cazorla), a local mythical creature also living in the mainland.^{[26][27][28][29][30]}

Plot

On the day of the Gommage, 32-year-old Gustave bids farewell to his former lover, Sophie, who has turned 33 and perishes along with everyone else of the same age. With only a year left to live, he joins Expedition 33 in hopes of slaying the Paintress. The Expedition meets catastrophe shortly after making landfall, when they are nearly wiped out by an old, white-haired man leading an army of monsters. After surviving the attack, Gustave manages to locate three other survivors: Lune, Sciel, and his foster sister Maelle. They also receive aid from a mysterious entity known as the Curator, who Maelle is able to communicate with. Maelle begins receiving visions of the white-haired man and a masked girl; they blame her for an unknown disaster. The party enlists the aid of the mythical creature Esquie in order to cross another sea to reach the Paintress. The white-haired man attacks again before they can set off, and Gustave dies defending Maelle. A man named Verso intervenes and helps the rest of the Expedition to escape.

Verso catches up with the party, explaining that he is a surviving member of the very first Expedition, and that the white-haired man is Renoir, their commander. Both stopped aging upon arrival on the continent. He asserts that Renoir has come to believe his immortality was granted by the Paintress and wishes to protect her at all costs. Verso, meanwhile, has grown tired of his immortality and joins the party. After crossing the sea and paying their respects to Gustave, the Expedition recruits Verso's friend, Monoco.

The Expedition reaches Renoir's mansion in Old Lumière in search of the Paintress' heart, which they need to destroy to disable the barrier protecting her. Verso admits that he is, in fact, Renoir's son, and the masked girl in Maelle's dreams is his sister, Alicia. After a battle, Renoir teleports the mansion and the heart away, thwarting Verso's plan. Lune suggests that they instead forge a powerful weapon from the hearts of highly dangerous ancient beings known as the Axons, which they use to pierce the barrier. The party enters the Monolith afterwards, killing Renoir along the way. They confront the Paintress, revealed to be Verso's mother, Aline, and manage to kill her, erasing the number on the Monolith. The Expedition returns to Lumière as heroes. Verso reads a letter from Alicia, revealing that Aline was trying to stall the Curator, who is in fact responsible for the Gommage, and the number on the Monolith was a warning to those about to die. Without Aline's protection, the entire population of Lumière vanishes, except for Verso.

In a flashback to the outside reality in early 20th-century Paris, it is revealed that the real Alicia, Verso, Aline, and Renoir are all Painters of the Dessendre family, magic users possessing the ability to create and inhabit worlds within magical Canvases. The real Verso died saving Alicia from a fire, but Alicia was left disfigured, half-blind and mute as a result. Grieving the death of her son, the real Aline entered Verso's Canvas, which contains Lumière and "painted" copies of Verso, Alicia, and Renoir. The real Renoir - manifesting within the Canvas as the Curator - seeks to destroy the Canvas for Aline to move on and bring her home, but against her powers he is only to achieve it gradually with the Gommage. Frustrated by the stalemate, Alicia's older sister Clea advises her to enter the Canvas and destroy it so their family can focus on their war with a rival faction, the Writers, who had previously manipulated Alicia and were responsible for the fire and Verso's death. Alicia obliges, but is reborn as Maelle after being overwhelmed by Aline's power.

With Maelle's "death", Alicia regains her memories and awakens in what remains of Lumière. She reunites with the painted Verso, who had been trying to expel Aline from the Canvas to end his immortality. Wanting to protect the Canvas world, Alicia uses her newly discovered Painter powers to revive the Expedition and battles her father for control. Optionally, Alicia can defeat her painted copy, prompting Verso to confess he let Gustave die to motivate Alicia to defeat Aline. After a final confrontation, Renoir explains that, as precious as the Canvas is to him and his family, destroying it is the only way to bring Aline and Alicia back to the real world so they can finally end the cycle of grief and move forward. He eventually relents and promises to "leave the lights on" for Alicia's eventual return.

Realizing that Alicia does not plan to leave the Canvas and will eventually die due to her prolonged stay, Verso reaches out to the last remnant of the real Verso's soul, attempting to remove it and thus destroy the Canvas. Alicia interjects, insisting that she would have a better life within the Canvas. The ending diverges based on the character the player chooses to play as in the final battle between the two:^[31]

- If the player chooses Alicia, she follows through with her wish to permanently live in the Canvas. She rebuilds Lumière and revives its people, including Gustave, Sophie, and a reluctant Verso. One day, Alicia attends Verso's concert alongside her friends. Before performing, Verso notices Alicia showing signs of decline, as Aline did.

- If the player chooses Verso, he banishes Alicia and removes the remaining piece of the real Verso's soul, destroying the Canvas and everything in it. Back in reality, the Dessendre family come to terms with their son's death and appear to have reconciled with each other. Alicia envisions Maelle, Verso, Gustave and her friends waving farewell to her before they all vanish.

Development

The ideas behind *Clair Obscur* originated in 2019 with Guillaume Broche, an employee of Ubisoft, not long before the COVID-19 pandemic;^[32] soon turning into a passion project inspired by his childhood favorites, most notably the *Final Fantasy* series.^[33] He sent out some requests for help to craft a demo to a group of other developers he knew as well as requests on Reddit in April 2020 looking for voice actors for said demo. In order to focus on his project full-time, Broche would leave Ubisoft that year and form Sandfall Interactive, alongside François Meurisse, an old friend, and fellow Ubisoft developer Tom Guillermin. The three co-founders would soon be joined by Nicholas Maxson-Francombe, Jennifer Svedberg-Yen and Lorien Testard; the six forming the kick-off team.^{[33][34]} Maxson-Francombe, the game's art director, was discovered and recruited off ArtStation by Broche. Svedberg-Yen, one of the voice actors who had stumbled upon Broche's Reddit post and was cast for the original demo, gained a more prominent role as development progressed, becoming the game's lead writer.^[33] Lorien Testard, the composer, was discovered by Broche through a post on a French indie video game forum where he linked a track from his SoundCloud page.^{[35][33][36]} After securing a partnership and funding from publisher Kepler Interactive in early 2023, Sandfall grew into a core team of about thirty developers, three of whom — including Broche and Guillermin — were former Ubisoft developers.^{[37][38][39][27][25][28]} The funding also allowed Sandfall to expand the manpower contributing to the project, having outsourced gameplay animation to a team of eight South Korean freelancers and quality assurance to dozens of QA testers from the firm QLOC, as well as receiving porting support from half a dozen developers from Ebb Software. The studio also notably hired performance capture artists, brought in musicians for the soundtrack recording sessions or delegated language localization as well as both English and French voice production to external contractors.^{[38][40]} Finally, the partnership with Kepler Interactive enabled Sandfall to pay for noted professional voice actors, including Charlie Cox, Andy Serkis and Ben Starr.^{[33][36]} Cox has jokingly stated he was in the studio for barely four hours to record his dialogue and felt like a fraud over being lauded for his performance; though Svedberg-Yen clarified on her social media accounts that his endeavor had taken around 8 hours.^[41]

Broche said one of the goals of *Clair Obscur* was to create a high fidelity turn-based RPG, which he felt had been neglected by AAA game developers.^[24] Besides *Final Fantasy*, *Clair Obscur* took inspiration from other Japanese role-playing games, including the *Persona* series;^[42] Broche notably praised *Persona 5* for its user interface and use of camera work during battles, "making it feel like you're watching a movie".^[43] Broche also considered *Lost Odyssey* and *Blue Dragon*, JRPGs developed for Microsoft's drive to help market the Xbox consoles in Japan, as an influence, particularly their use of quick time events during combat.^[44] According to producer François Meurisse, the game drew inspiration from SquareSoft's *Final Fantasy VIII*, *Final Fantasy IX* and *Final Fantasy X* in particular, while the dodge and parry mechanics were influenced by FromSoftware's *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice*.^[45]

Development initially began under the codename "Project W",^[46] and was first known as *We Lost* around the time that Broche sought help on Reddit. The initial demo showcased a steampunk setting inspired by Victorian era England, with more science fiction elements, including zombies and aliens. About six

months into this approach, potential investors suggested that Broche should "think bigger", leading him to reset the entire narrative, though he kept some of the characters they had already conceived. The new setting was based on a painting Broche admired, which depicted a painter entering her own work, as well as a short story written by Svedberg-Yen.^[47]

Development had begun using Unreal Engine 4 at early stages and later switching to Unreal Engine 5 to take advantage of Unreal Engine 5's improvements in rendering and animation.^{[25][28]} The switch to UE5 was motivated by its Nanite and Lumen features, allowing for higher-fidelity assets and more-realistic lighting, respectively.^[48] The adoption of Lumen necessitated reworking the lighting for most environments.^[48] Additionally, UE5 brought better character creation support, allowing them to switch from Reallusion's Character Creator.^[48] The developers also made use of ready-made assets for background objects such as rocks, which allows them to focus on creating "hero assets", i.e., large-scale assets that make an impression on the viewer.^[48] Broche credits the simplicity of modern game engines to help bring the product together.^[33]

The game went gold on March 22, 2025, coincidentally 33 days before the game's release.^[49] The physical version of the game was distributed by Maximum Entertainment in North America and Bandai Namco Entertainment in Europe.^[50]

Broche has expressed interest in developing sequels or similar games in the same setting as to develop a *Clair Obscur* franchise, though he was unsure whether these would narratively continue from *Expedition 33*.^[51]

Film adaptation

In January 2025, Story Kitchen announced a live-action adaptation of the game with developer Sandfall Interactive.^[52]

Regarding the game's storyline, Guillaume Broche and Tom Guillermin cite the science fantasy novel *The Horde of Counterwind* by Alain Damasio as inspiration.^[53]

Reception

Critical response

Reception	
Aggregate scores	
Aggregator	Score
<u>Metacritic</u>	(PC) 91/100 ^[54] (PS5) 93/100^[55] (XSXS) 91/100 ^[56]
<u>OpenCritic</u>	97% recommend ^[57]

Review scores	
Publication	Score
<i>Destructoid</i>	9.5/10 ^[58]
<i>Edge</i>	10/10 ^[59]
<i>Eurogamer</i>	4/5 ^[60]
<i>Famitsu</i>	36/40 ^[61]
<i>Game Informer</i>	9/10 ^[62]
<i>GameSpot</i>	9/10 ^[63]
<i>GamesRadar+</i>	4.5/5 ^[64]
<i>Hardcore Gamer</i>	4.5/5 ^[65]
<i>IGN</i>	9/10 ^[66]
<i>PC Gamer (US)</i>	70/100 ^[67]
<i>PCGamesN</i>	8/10 ^[68]
<i>Push Square</i>	9/10 ^[69]
<i>RPGamer</i>	5/5 ^[70]
<i>RPGFan</i>	99/100 ^[71]
<i>Shacknews</i>	9/10 ^[72]
<i>The Guardian</i>	4/5 ^[73]
<i>VG247</i>	5/5 ^[74]

Clair Obscur: Expedition 33 received "universal acclaim" from critics, according to review aggregator website *Metacritic*.^{[54][55][56]} This sentiment was also echoed by the users, with the game attaining the highest Metacritic userscore of all time as of May 2025.^[75] *OpenCritic* reported a top critic average score of 92% across all platforms, with 97% of critics recommending the game.^[57]

Clair Obscur's art direction and visual world design were praised by reviewers.^{[60][66][76]} *Edge* described them as "dreamily intoxicating",^[59] a sentiment echoed by Richard Wakeling of *GameSpot*, who nonetheless criticized the world for being "mechanically uninteresting [...] to explore".^[63] Additional criticism was directed at the absence of a *mini-map*, which can lead to occasional disorientation.^{[62][60][68][64]}

The story received critical acclaim, with particular praise for the voice acting, which was noted for bringing the characters to life and effectively supporting the narrative.^{[63][74][68]} *IGN*'s Michael Higham commended the game for the way it "frames mortality, grief, and the small moments of joy we find".^[66] Liam Croft of *Push Square* noted that "every *cutscene* remains gripping, with an already intriguing plot heightened by [...] excellent voice acting".^[69]

Reviewers were impressed by the soundtrack and particularly praised its adaptability.^{[63][60][66]} *Game Informer*'s Kyle Hilliard highlighted the contrast between the "somber piano music and haunting vocals", which underscore the characters' emotional experiences, and the combat themes that "bring the energy back up at precisely the right moment".^[62] *Edge* described the score as immense and "operatic".^[59]

The gameplay was praised for its modern approach to traditional Japanese-style turn-based combat.^{[63][62][74]} Malindy Hetfeld of *The Guardian* noted that "a successful counter felt deeply satisfying every time".^[73] Ed Nightingale of *Eurogamer* further highlighted the variety in character fighting styles, each one introducing "a new system to learn", as well as the extensive options for character customization.^[60] Josh Brown for *PCGamesN* described the game as a "hyper-stimulating take on a genre once deemed too slow and stale for the HD era".^[68]

Clair Obscur was thus regarded as a major success by reviewers despite some minor shortcomings being highlighted. *Edge* conceded that the ability to do side quests, leveling the player up by a lot, could make the boss fights too easy to pose a satisfying challenge—they admitted it was "imprudent" to suggest such an alteration to what they felt was a "masterpiece".^[59] Wakeling criticized the underwhelming exploration and small quality-of-life issues, but concluded that "these missteps aren't enough to significantly detract from a game with all the makings of an RPG classic".^[63]

High profile developers, including Hideo Kojima, Neil Druckmann and Ken Levine, have voiced praise for *Clair Obscur*, whether for the flexibility demonstrated by the small development team, the game's story, or the ability to achieve a product of great quality while avoiding the pitfalls of excessive monetization that can plague games developed by large AAA studios.^{[77][78][79]}

Sales

Clair Obscur: Expedition 33 sold 500,000 units within the first 24 hours after its release, 1 million units within 3 days^[80] and 2 million units within 12 days.^[81] As of 27 May 2025, the game had sold 3.3 million units.^[82] Upon reaching the 1 million sales milestone, President of France Emmanuel Macron celebrated the game's achievement, stating it was "a shining example of French audacity and creativity."^[83] The mayor of Montpellier, Michaël Delafosse, also congratulated the team on their success in late May, stating it will be "a reference in the international history of video games".^[84]

The game's soundtrack reached the top position on Billboard's Classical Music and Classical Crossover Music charts during the first week of May 2025.^[85]

Accolades

Year	Award	Category	Result	Ref.
2025	<u>World Soundtrack Awards</u>	Game Music Award (Lorien Testard)	Pending (Nominated)	^{[86][87]}
	<u>TIGA Awards</u>	Action and Adventure	Pending	^[88]
		Narrative/Storytelling	Pending	

Notes

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- a. *Clair obscur* is the French translation of the Italian word *chiaroscuro*, an art style that emphasises the differences between light and dark.^[2]

b. "Gommage" is French for *erasing*.^[23]

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External links

- Official website (<https://www.expedition33.com/>)
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